

THE GRAND OLD WAY TO DO IT – XUL

To know our future, we must know our past!

Around 10 years ago, somebody came up with a plan. A plan that a browser shouldn't be limited to what the developer of the browser shipped it as – but what the users want it to be. That meant giving anyone the authority to make changes to the default form and functionality provided by the browser. Such power in the hands of the people who were probably not actively involved in the development of a browser was unheard of. Fast forward to today, and such practices are the staple of our internet experience. About 85% of browser users take advantage of extensions, millions of which have been created by non-Mozilla employees – ranging from tools as simple as ad-blockers to complex DOM investigation and network sniffing tools.

Of course, that 'somebody' who was responsible for this revolution was a figurative for Mozilla. XUL (pronounced “zool” and rhyming with “cool”) was developed by the organisation with the intent of providing tools for writing GUIs. Essentially a subset of XML, it was championed as a user-interface markup language, and is short for XML User-Interface Language.